

AGRICULTURE TEACHING SYLLABUS

PRIMARY SCHOOL — STANDARD 3 (GRADE 3)

8 Units | 3 Terms | Full Academic Year

Prepared for classroom use in the Malawian primary school context

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The development of this Grade 3 Agriculture Teaching Syllabus has been a collaborative effort, and gratitude is extended to everyone who contributed their time, expertise, and insight to its completion.

Sincere appreciation goes to the primary school teachers whose classroom experience shaped the practical, age-appropriate approach taken throughout this syllabus. Their understanding of how young learners engage with agricultural concepts, and their commitment to hands-on, experiential teaching, has been invaluable in ensuring the content is both realistic and achievable within a typical school term.

Thanks are also due to agricultural extension officers and community farmers who generously shared local knowledge of crop cycles, livestock practices, and seasonal farming activities specific to the Malawian context. Their input ensured that the examples, crops, and practices referenced in this syllabus reflect the lived agricultural environment of the learners it is intended to serve.

Appreciation is extended to curriculum development specialists whose guidance on structuring units, topics, aims, and success criteria helped shape a syllabus that is both pedagogically sound and easy for teachers to follow and adapt.

Gratitude also goes to the school administrators and head teachers who recognise the value of practical agricultural education in building life skills, food security awareness, and environmental responsibility among young learners, and who continue to support garden-based learning within their schools.

Finally, this work is dedicated to the learners themselves — the young farmers, gardeners, and stewards of the land who will carry forward what they learn in these lessons into their homes, their communities, and, for some, into a lifelong relationship with the land.

It is hoped that this syllabus will serve as a practical and inspiring guide for teachers as they nurture curiosity, responsibility, and a genuine appreciation for agriculture in every learner.

INTRODUCTION

Rationale

Agriculture is central to the livelihood, food security, and economy of Malawi. Introducing learners to agricultural concepts at an early age builds practical life skills, an appreciation for where food comes from, and a foundation of environmental responsibility. This syllabus is designed for Standard 3 (Grade 3) learners and combines simple theoretical knowledge with hands-on, garden-based activities suited to their developmental stage.

General Aims of the Syllabus

- To develop learners' basic knowledge and understanding of agricultural practices relevant to their community.
- To build practical skills in crop production, animal care, and safe use of simple farm tools.
- To foster positive attitudes towards farming, food security, and environmental conservation.
- To connect classroom learning with real, hands-on activity through the school and home garden.
- To lay a foundation of agricultural literacy that learners will build on in later grades.

Teaching and Learning Methodology

Lessons should be predominantly practical and activity-based, making use of the school garden, real tools, and locally available samples wherever possible. Recommended approaches include:

- Demonstration followed by guided practice
- Small-group and pair activities in the garden
- Discussion and question-and-answer sessions
- Use of real objects, pictures, and simple charts
- Short field observations within the school compound or nearby farms

Assessment Strategies

Assessment should be continuous and largely practical, appropriate to the age of the learners. Suggested methods include:

- Oral questions and class discussion
- Observation of practical garden tasks
- Simple written or picture-based exercises
- Short end-of-unit checks against the stated success criteria
- A simple end-of-term practical project (e.g. a class garden bed)

Duration and Structure

This syllabus contains 8 units spread across a full academic year of 3 terms. A suggested pacing guide is provided below; teachers should adjust timing to suit their local school calendar and available garden space.

SYLLABUS OVERVIEW

Term	Units Covered	Focus
Term 1	Unit 1: Introduction to Agriculture Unit 2: The School and Home Garden Unit 3: Crop Production	Foundations and getting the garden started
Term 2	Unit 4: Soil and Water Unit 5: Livestock and Animal Care Unit 6: Farm Tools and Safety	Resources, animals, and safe practice
Term 3	Unit 7: Agriculture and the Environment Unit 8: Food from the Farm Revision and end-of-year practical project	Conservation, nutrition, and consolidation

UNIT 1: INTRODUCTION TO AGRICULTURE

1.1 Meaning and Importance of Agriculture

Sub-topics

- Meaning of agriculture
- Agriculture in our daily lives
- Why we grow crops and keep animals

Aim

To help learners understand what agriculture is and why it is important to families and the community.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can explain in their own words what agriculture means
- Learners can name three reasons why agriculture is important
- Learners can give examples of agricultural activities happening around their home

1.2 Types of Agricultural Activities

Sub-topics

- Crop farming
- Livestock keeping
- Fishing
- Forestry

Aim

To introduce learners to the different branches of agriculture practised in Malawi.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can identify and name the four main types of agricultural activities
- Learners can match pictures of farming activities to their correct type
- Learners can describe one activity from each type

UNIT 2: THE SCHOOL AND HOME GARDEN

2.1 Preparing a Garden

Sub-topics

- Choosing a garden site
- Clearing the land
- Digging and loosening the soil
- Making garden beds and ridges

Aim

To equip learners with basic skills for preparing land for planting.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can describe the steps taken to prepare a garden
- Learners can help clear a small plot of land safely
- Learners can make a simple garden bed with guidance

2.2 Planting

Sub-topics

- Choosing good seeds
- Spacing of seeds and seedlings
- Depth of planting
- Best time of planting

Aim

To teach learners correct methods of planting seeds and seedlings.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can plant seeds at the correct spacing and depth
- Learners can explain why spacing is important
- Learners can identify good seeds from poor seeds

UNIT 3: CROP PRODUCTION

3.1 Types of Crops

Sub-topics

- Food crops (maize, beans, cassava, sweet potatoes)
- Cash crops (tobacco, cotton, groundnuts)
- Vegetables and fruits

Aim

To help learners identify and classify crops grown in Malawi.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can name at least five crops grown in their community
- Learners can sort crops into food crops and cash crops
- Learners can identify crops from pictures or real samples

3.2 Caring for Crops

Sub-topics

- Weeding
- Watering
- Protecting crops from pests
- Applying manure and fertiliser

Aim

To develop learners' understanding of how to care for growing crops.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can explain why weeding is important
- Learners can demonstrate correct watering of a garden bed
- Learners can identify common pests that damage crops

3.3 Harvesting and Storage

Sub-topics

- Signs that a crop is ready for harvest
- Harvesting methods
- Simple storage methods

Aim

To teach learners when and how crops are harvested and kept safe after harvest.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can describe signs that show a crop is ready to harvest
- Learners can explain simple ways of storing harvested crops
- Learners can state why proper storage prevents food loss

UNIT 4: SOIL AND WATER

4.1 Types and Properties of Soil

Sub-topics

- Sandy soil
- Clay soil
- Loam soil
- Which soil is best for crops

Aim

To help learners recognise different soil types and their suitability for farming.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can describe the feel and colour of at least two soil types
- Learners can identify soil samples brought from home
- Learners can explain why loam soil is good for most crops

4.2 Keeping Soil Healthy

Sub-topics

- Adding manure and compost
- The idea of crop rotation
- Avoiding soil erosion

Aim

To introduce learners to simple practices that keep soil fertile and healthy.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can explain what manure does to soil
- Learners can describe one way to stop soil from washing away
- Learners can state why farmers should not plant the same crop every season

4.3 Water for Farming

Sub-topics

- Sources of water for crops
- Ways of watering a garden
- Saving water

Aim

To teach learners the role of water in growing healthy crops and animals.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can name at least two sources of water for farming
- Learners can demonstrate a safe way of watering plants
- Learners can suggest one way of saving water in the garden

UNIT 5: LIVESTOCK AND ANIMAL CARE

5.1 Domestic Animals

Sub-topics

- Types of domestic animals (chickens, goats, cattle, pigs)
- Products we get from animals

Aim

To introduce learners to common domestic animals kept in their community and their uses.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can name at least four domestic animals kept at home
- Learners can list products obtained from these animals, such as milk, eggs, and meat
- Learners can match an animal to the product it provides

5.2 Caring for Animals

Sub-topics

- Feeding animals
- Providing shelter
- Keeping animals clean and healthy
- Water for animals

Aim

To help learners understand the basic needs of domestic animals.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can state the basic needs of a farm animal
- Learners can describe how to keep an animal shelter clean
- Learners can explain why animals need clean water daily

UNIT 6: FARM TOOLS AND SAFETY

6.1 Common Farm Tools

Sub-topics

- Hoe
- Panga knife (machete)
- Watering can
- Wheelbarrow
- Rake

Aim

To familiarise learners with common farm tools and their correct uses.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can name and identify at least five farm tools
- Learners can match each tool to the task it is used for
- Learners can demonstrate the correct way of holding a hoe

6.2 Safety on the Farm

Sub-topics

- Handling sharp tools carefully
- Wearing appropriate clothing
- Washing hands after garden work
- Keeping tools away from young children

Aim

To develop safety awareness when learners work in the garden or handle farm tools.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can list three safety rules to follow when using farm tools
- Learners can explain why they must wash their hands after garden work
- Learners can demonstrate safe carrying of a garden tool

UNIT 7: AGRICULTURE AND THE ENVIRONMENT

7.1 Trees and Forests

Sub-topics

- Importance of trees
- Planting trees
- Effects of cutting down trees

Aim

To help learners appreciate the value of trees and forests to agriculture and life.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can give three reasons why trees are important
- Learners can take part in planting a tree at school
- Learners can explain one bad effect of cutting down too many trees

7.2 Caring for the Environment

Sub-topics

- Avoiding bush fires
- Proper disposal of rubbish
- Protecting water sources
- Simple conservation practices

Aim

To instil good environmental practices that support sustainable agriculture.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can state why bush fires are harmful
- Learners can describe one way to keep a water source clean
- Learners can identify one action they can take to protect their environment

UNIT 8: FOOD FROM THE FARM

8.1 From Farm to Table

Sub-topics

- How food travels from garden to kitchen
- Washing and preparing farm food
- Reducing food waste

Aim

To help learners trace the journey of food from the farm to their plate.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can describe the steps food takes from farm to table
- Learners can explain why food should be washed before eating
- Learners can suggest one way to avoid wasting food at home

8.2 Healthy Eating from the Farm

Sub-topics

- Farm foods that keep us healthy
- Balanced meals using local produce
- Growing a simple kitchen garden

Aim

To connect agricultural produce with good nutrition and healthy living.

Success Criteria — by the end of this topic, learners should be able to:

- Learners can name farm foods that are good for their bodies
- Learners can describe what a balanced plate of local food looks like
- Learners can suggest three foods to grow in a small kitchen garden